SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | SOUPS, BEANS & VEGETABLES

Acquacotta Maremmana: Authentic Tuscan Peasant Vegetable & Poached Egg Soup

PREP: 10 mins | COOK: 25 mins | TOTAL: 35 mins | SERVINGS: 4 servings ($1.45/serving) | CALORIES: 380 kcal

INGREDIENTS

* 3 large Red or Sweet Yellow Onions (thinly sliced half-moons)
* 3 ribs Fresh Celery (with leafy tops) (sliced on the bias)
* 1 large bunch (300g) Swiss Chard or Tuscan Kale (Cavolo Nero) (stems diced, leaves chopped into ribbons)
* 3 tbsp (45ml) Tuscan Extra-Virgin Olive Oil (plus extra for drizzling)
* 3 cloves Fresh Garlic (2 minced for soup + 1 whole clove for rubbing toast)
* 400g (1 can / 14 oz) Crushed San Marzano Tomatoes
* 1 Liter (4 cups) Warm Vegetable Broth (or Water + Parmigiano Rind)
* 4 large Fresh Eggs (for poaching in the broth)
* 4 thick slices Day-Old Tuscan or Sourdough Bread (toasted golden)
* 60g (2/3 cup) Aged Pecorino Toscano or Parmigiano-Reggiano (freshly grated)

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Slowly Sweating the Onion & Celery Base (11 mins)

Warm 3 tablespoons of olive oil in a wide Dutch oven over medium-low heat. Add the sliced onions, celery, diced chard stems, and a pinch of salt. Cook gently for 10 minutes until the onions are silky, translucent, and sweet, then stir in the minced garlic for 1 minute.

Step 2: Simmer with Tomatoes & Chopped Greens (15 mins)

Add the crushed San Marzano tomatoes, chopped Swiss chard leaves, warm vegetable broth, and optional Parmigiano rind. Bring to a gentle simmer, cover partially, and cook for 15 minutes until the greens are tender and the broth is rich and savory.

Step 3: Poach the Eggs Directly in the Broth (4 mins)

Use the back of a ladle to press 4 small indentations in the simmering greens. Crack 1 egg into a small ramekin and slide it gently into each nest. Sprinkle a tiny pinch of salt and Pecorino over the eggs, cover the pot with a lid, and simmer on low for 3-4 minutes until the whites are set and yolks remain runny.

Step 4: Layer Over Garlic Bread & Pecorino (2 mins)

Rub the 4 toasted country bread slices with the raw garlic clove, place 1 slice at the bottom of each warmed bowl, and shower with grated Pecorino. Ladle the hot vegetable soup over the bread so it softens, crown each bowl with a poached egg, and finish with extra Pecorino and olive oil.

NONNA’S CHEF TIPS:

- Cracking each egg into a small teacup before sliding it into the simmering greens ensures the yolk stays intact and the white stays neatly gathered.
- Wait 60 seconds after ladling the hot broth over the toasted bread before serving-the crust drinks up the tomato broth while keeping a chewy bite.